

Activity 10 — Measuring Effectiveness: Did It Actually Work?

ShopFront SG — 90 days later, and the numbers are ambiguous

Topic	Topic 3
Objective	A7 · K7 — Evaluate the effectiveness of implemented solutions and implementation plans.
Duration	45 minutes
Grouping	Teams of 3-5
Tools	ChatGPT / Copilot / Gemini, Pareto Chart ed-tool
Ed-tool	Pareto Chart Tool — https://alfredang.github.io/paretochart/

The Scenario

Ninety days have passed. The COO has the results and she is not sure what to make of them. Some numbers moved well. Some did not move at all. One moved in the wrong direction. And the quarter included the Great Singapore Sale, which everyone is now using to explain whichever result suits their argument.

The Head of Marketing says the improvement is obviously seasonal. The IT lead says the improvement is obviously the CDN. Finance wants to know whether to release the next S\$200,000 tranche.

Your team must evaluate honestly: what worked, what did not, what you cannot yet tell, and what you recommend next. "It's working" is not an acceptable answer.

The Evidence

ShopFront SG — 90-day results against baseline

Metric	Baseline	Target	Day 90 actual	Verdict
App page load	4.8 s	under 2.0 s	1.7 s	Target met
Checkout completion	51%	68%	63%	Improved, short
Cart abandonment	74%	60%	64%	Improved, short
Online sales / month	S\$1.9m	S\$2.8m	S\$2.5m	Improved, short
CSAT	70%	85%	72%	Barely moved
Complaint tickets / week	410	150	295	Improved, short
Product return rate	12%	5%	13%	WORSE
Repeat purchase (90-day)	29%	40%	31%	Barely moved
Guest checkout adoption	n/a	n/a	44% of orders	New data
Supplier QC checklist	0	12 of 12	4 of 12	Behind

adoption				
Cart recovery emails sent	n/a	n/a	18,400	Live
Cart recovery conversion	n/a	8%	3.1%	Underperforming

Discussion Questions

1. Give a verdict on each metric. Overall — did this programme succeed? Defend a single-sentence answer to the COO.
2. The product return rate got WORSE (12% to 13%) despite the QC initiative. Give the most likely explanation, and say what evidence would confirm or refute it.
3. App load smashed its target but CSAT barely moved. Explain this using leading versus lagging indicators. How long would you expect CSAT to lag?
4. The Great Singapore Sale sits inside the measurement window. How would you isolate the programme effect from the seasonal effect? What would you have done differently at day 0 to make this answerable?
5. Cart recovery converts at 3.1% against an 8% target. Is the solution wrong, or the implementation, or the target? How would you tell the difference — and what does each answer imply?
6. Make the call to the CFO: release the next S\$200,000, adjust, or stop. Justify it with the evidence, and name what would change your mind.

Step-by-Step

7. Review the 90-day results table against the original problem statement baselines from Activity 1.
8. Assign a verdict to every metric: Met / Partially met / Not met / Deteriorated.
9. For each improved metric, ask: what CAUSED this? Mark each as Attributable, Partially attributable, or Confounded.
10. Investigate the return rate deterioration. Note that only 4 of 12 suppliers adopted the checklist — what does that tell you about whether the solution was ever actually tested?
11. Separate all metrics into LEADING and LAGGING. Check whether any target was set on an unrealistic horizon.
12. Identify how the Great Singapore Sale confounds the sales figures. Decide what analysis would isolate the programme effect.
13. Diagnose the cart recovery underperformance: wrong solution, wrong implementation, or wrong target? State what data would settle it.
14. Run the GenAI evaluation prompt from the slide.
15. Check the AI's attribution claims critically. Mark anywhere it claimed credit the evidence cannot support.
16. Trace the supplier QC shortfall back to your Activity 9 stakeholder analysis. Did you predict this resistance? What would you have done differently?
17. Write your recommendation to the CFO in three sentences: the verdict, the decision on the S\$200k, and what would change your mind.
18. List the three things you would measure differently if you started again.

The GenAI Prompt

Act as a performance evaluation analyst. Assess whether this improvement programme worked. Be rigorous and do not flatter the results.

Results after 90 days (metric: baseline -> target -> actual):

App load 4.8s -> <2.0s -> 1.7s
Checkout completion 51% -> 68% -> 63%
Cart abandonment 74% -> 60% -> 64%
Online sales S\$1.9m -> S\$2.8m -> S\$2.5m
CSAT 70% -> 85% -> 72%
Complaints/week 410 -> 150 -> 295
Product return rate 12% -> 5% -> 13% (WORSE)
Repeat purchase 29% -> 40% -> 31%
Supplier QC checklist adopted by 4 of 12 suppliers
Cart recovery conversion 3.1% against an 8% target

Context: the 90-day window included the Great Singapore Sale.

Produce:

1. A verdict per metric: Met / Partially met / Not met / Deteriorated
2. Which solutions can be credited with which movements – and where you CANNOT establish attribution, say so explicitly and explain why
3. Why the product return rate got WORSE despite the QC initiative – give the most likely explanation and state what evidence would confirm it
4. Separate LEADING from LAGGING indicators here, and explain why CSAT and repeat purchase barely moved even though operational metrics improved
5. How the Great Singapore Sale confounds this evaluation, and what analysis would isolate the programme effect from the seasonal effect
6. A clear recommendation to the CFO on releasing the next S\$200k tranche: continue, adjust, or stop – with reasoning
7. The three things you would measure differently next time

Trainer Debrief

Expected answers and the points to draw out. Trainer reference.

EXPECTED EVALUATION:

ATTRIBUTION IS THE CENTRAL SKILL. App load 4.8s -> 1.7s is cleanly attributable to the CDN and caching — technical, direct, no plausible alternative cause. Checkout completion is PARTIALLY attributable to guest checkout (44% adoption is strong supporting evidence). Online sales, however, are CONFOUNDED by the Great Singapore Sale and cannot be cleanly attributed either way. A team that credits the full S\$0.6m to the programme is overclaiming; a team that dismisses it as seasonal is underclaiming. The honest answer is: not determinable with this design, and here is what would have made it determinable.

THE RETURN RATE PUZZLE — the most instructive result on the board. Most likely explanation: only 4 of 12 suppliers adopted the QC checklist, so the intervention barely happened. Simultaneously, higher conversion and GSS volume brought in more first-time and discount-driven buyers, who return at a higher rate than loyal customers. So the return rate rose because of a MIX SHIFT, not because quality fell. Confirming evidence: segment return rate by supplier (adopters vs non-adopters) and by customer type (new vs repeat, full-price vs discounted). This is the moment learners see that a metric moving the wrong way does not automatically mean the solution failed — you must decompose before you conclude.

LEADING vs LAGGING: app load, checkout completion and guest checkout adoption are LEADING — they respond within days. CSAT, repeat purchase and brand perception are LAGGING — they reflect accumulated experience across multiple purchase cycles and typically lag two to three cycles, i.e. 6-9 months for a fashion retailer. Expecting CSAT to move in 90 days was a planning error, not an execution failure. The target itself was wrong.

CART RECOVERY at 3.1% vs 8%: distinguish the three diagnoses. Wrong solution (cart recovery does not work for this audience); wrong implementation (poor timing, weak copy, no incentive, emails hitting spam); wrong target (8% was benchmarked from a different sector). The way to tell: check open and click rates. High open + low conversion = offer/landing problem. Low open = deliverability or timing problem. Industry benchmarks for fashion cart-recovery sit around 3-5%, which strongly suggests the TARGET was unrealistic. Teams that immediately conclude 'the solution failed' have skipped the diagnosis — and that is exactly the behaviour the whole course exists to correct.

RECOMMENDATION TO THE CFO — the defensible answer is CONTINUE WITH ADJUSTMENT: the technical solutions delivered and are attributable; supplier QC did not actually get implemented (4 of 12) so it has not been tested and should not be abandoned on non-adoption; cart recovery needs its target rebased and its execution diagnosed; CSAT needs a longer horizon. Redirect effort to supplier adoption — which is a CHANGE MANAGEMENT failure, traceable straight back to Activity 9's prediction that suppliers would resist. That connection is the strongest single moment in the course: the resistance they predicted is the resistance that actually materialised, and it is the reason a metric missed.

KEY TEACHING POINTS:

1. 'IT'S WORKING' IS NOT AN EVALUATION. Metric-by-metric verdicts against baseline and target, with explicit attribution and explicit uncertainty, is.
2. EVALUATION IS ONLY POSSIBLE BECAUSE ACTIVITY 1 CAPTURED A BASELINE. Say this out loud — the course has now closed its loop, and learners should feel why the six-element problem statement mattered 16 hours ago.
3. DISTINGUISH SOLUTION FAILURE FROM IMPLEMENTATION FAILURE. Supplier QC did not fail; it was not adopted. Those demand completely different responses — one means change the solution, the other means fix the rollout.
4. CONFOUNDING IS ALWAYS PRESENT IN REAL WORKPLACES. You will rarely get a clean experiment. Good practice: define the measurement window at day 0, hold a control (e.g. staged rollout by region), and segment the data. Say what you cannot determine — that honesty is what makes the rest of your evaluation credible to a CFO.
5. GenAI will produce a confident, well-structured evaluation that quietly overclaims attribution unless you explicitly instruct it to flag what cannot be determined. Note that the prompt on the slide does exactly that — and compare it against what the AI returns without that instruction. That contrast is the AI-literacy takeaway of the entire course.

Self-Check — Is Your Output Finished?

Your evaluation is credible when: every metric has a verdict against its baseline AND target; attribution is stated explicitly and confounded results are named as confounded rather than claimed; you can explain the worsening return rate without concluding the solution failed; you distinguish solution failure from implementation failure for supplier QC; your CFO recommendation names what would change your mind; and you can trace at least one missed metric back to a stakeholder resistance you predicted in Activity 9. If your evaluation credits the programme with everything that improved and blames the season for everything that did not, you have written advocacy, not evaluation.